THE GUIDE YOU COMMENTED FOR

# How to make a 1940s noir story reel like this one

The workflow behind "The Diamond Invention": a 56-second animated history reel in an art-deco noir look, with a narrator, music and sound effects, and no camera or face. Seven steps, the prompts we used, and the mistakes that cost us time.




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# What you need

| | |
|---|---|
| **An AI assistant** | Claude or ChatGPT to tighten the script and check every fact against real sources. |
| **ElevenLabs** | The narrator voice (with word timings), the music track and the sound effects. A paid plan is needed for commercial use. |
| **An animation tool** | We used **Claude Code**, which writes the animation as code and renders it to MP4. Any motion tool works with the same plan (After Effects, Rive, CapCut keyframes). |

STEP 1

# A hook that starts an argument

Open on something everyone believes, and say it isn't true: **"Diamonds aren't rare."** People stop scrolling to disagree. Then pay it off with a story, not a lecture. Plan for **110–130 spoken words**, about 50 seconds.

- **Hook (0–3 s):** the claim, plus an open loop ("One ad made you believe they were"). Which ad? They stay to find out.
- **Story:** a crisis, the people behind the plan, the moment it worked.
- **Twist:** the hidden reason ("Forever also meant: never resell it").
- **Send line:** one person to share it with ("someone who's about to buy a ring").

**PROMPT · FACT-CHECK**

Here is my reel script. Check every name, date and number against primary sources and list the source for each. Mark each claim correct, needs a tweak (give the fix), or can't be verified (suggest safer wording). Keep the tone and length.

[paste script]

**Real example:** sources disagree on how many engagement rings had diamonds before and after the campaign, so that number stayed out. "De Beers controls the mines" made it in, because the main source supports it.

STEP 2

# A style bible, not a mood board

Before any visuals, write the rules the whole reel obeys. Ours: **1940s art-deco noir**, a 1940s magazine ad lit like a film-noir still.

- **Palette:** 4 colour families with hex codes, and the share of black in every frame (55–65%).
- **One accent with one job:** ice-blue appears *only* on diamonds, so the eye always lands on them.
- **Type:** one deco display face for titles (Limelight), one clean face for labels (Josefin Sans).
- **Light:** one hard key light per scene, crisp black shadows, Venetian-blind stripes indoors.
- **A small set of moves:** three ways text may enter, three signature transitions, nothing else.

## Our palette: "deco noir"

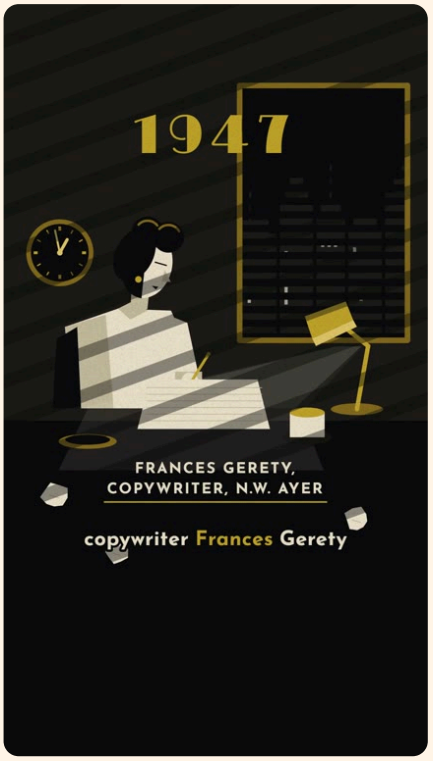
| #0B0B0D black | #1E1C1A charcoal | #F2E6CF cream | #C9A227 gold | #8A6A1C gold shade | #9FDDF2 diamonds only |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|




1930s: the price graph falls on the shop window




1938: the deal, lit by a sunset window




1947: one desk lamp, hard blind shadows

STEP 3

# The narrator voice

- Direct it like a **true-crime narrator telling you a secret**: low, close, confident, never salesy. We used the "True Crime & Horror Narrator" from the ElevenLabs library.
- **Spell for the voice, not the reader:** "nineteen thirty-eight", "N. W. Air" for N.W. Ayer, "Gerrity" for Gerety. Captions keep the real spelling.
- **Too long?** Shorten the pauses between sentences, not the words. Our first take ran 59 s; about 14 s of it was pauses.
- Leave the big line slow. "A… Diamond… Is… Forever." keeps its gaps.

STEP 4

# A shot list timed to the voice

Use the word timings so every title lands on its word. A new picture every **3–5 seconds**:

| Time | Voice | Picture | Title |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0.0–3.8 | "Diamonds aren't rare…" | A ring box snaps open; pull out to a mountain of diamonds in a vault | DIAMONDS AREN'T RARE. |
| 8.5–12.8 | "…depends on scarcity." | Diamonds drip down a chute; a gloved hand slides the gate shut | SCARCITY (stamped on the word) |
| 33.3–37.0 | "A Diamond Is Forever." | A 1940s ad page; one word stamps on per spoken word | A / DIAMOND / IS / FOREVER |
| 46.3–50.8 | "…It sold a feeling." | A giant diamond turns into a faceted heart | IT SOLD A FEELING. |

> **The hook rule:** frame one is already moving. Ours opens mid-snap, with the box lid already flying open.

STEP 5

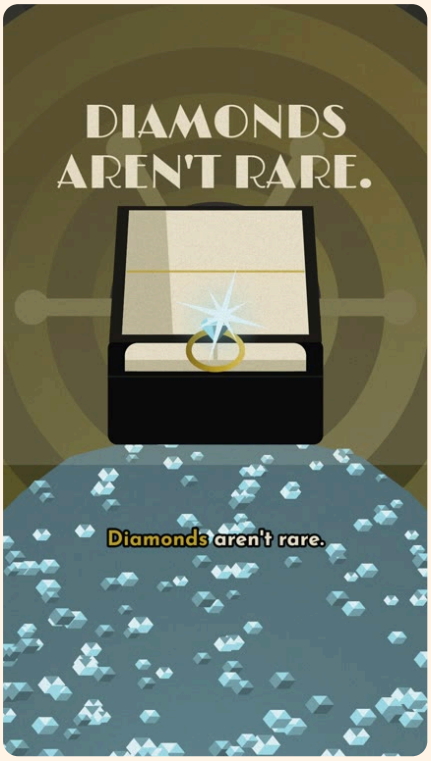
# Build the visuals

Claude Code drew every frame as code from the style bible and the shot list, then rendered a 1080×1920 MP4. The recipe for this look:

- **Silhouettes with a rim:** draw each figure once in cream, shifted a few pixels toward the light, then again in black on top. You get a crisp rim light for free.
- **3–5 layers per scene** moving at different speeds (foreground 1.0, background 0.3), so a slow push-in feels deep.
- **Text enters three ways only:** a gold rule wipes it on, letters settle from wide spacing, or it stamps down with a tiny shake.
- **Signature transitions:** a diamond glint whose ray opens the next scene, a black shadow sweep, and match cuts (diamond to diamond).

**PROMPT · CLAUDE CODE**

Make a 9:16, 1080x1920 animated reel from docs/script.md. Follow its style bible exactly: palette, one key light per scene, text entrances and transitions. Draw everything as flat vector shapes on a canvas, in 3-5 parallax layers per scene. Time every title to the word timings in audio/vo.words.json. Show me a contact sheet (one frame per second) before the full render.




The hook: the claim plus a visual reveal




A gold ghost of the 1940s ad behind today's proposal




"It sold a feeling": the diamond becomes a heart

STEP 6

# Music that follows the story

**Map the mood beat by beat,** then ask ElevenLabs Music for one section per beat: noir jazz for the Depression, a hopeful lift for the deal, a full swing band for Hollywood, a hush for the copywriter, a swell for "Forever", an ominous groove for "never resell".

> **Our costly mistake:** we asked one section to "fade to near silence". The music went silent for 9 seconds and never came back for the next two sections. Ask for "very quiet and sparse" instead, and make the quiet in the mix. Then check the track's level second by second: an AI listener described the missing sections as if it had heard them.

| Mixing rule | Number |
|---|---|
| Music under the voice | about 9 dB quieter than speech, plus about 3 dB more under words |
| Quiet beats | a gentle dip of about 7 dB, never a dead stop |
| Last line → end card | about 5 dB lower from the last line, about 10 dB lower under the end card |
| Final loudness | −14 LUFS, true peak no higher than −1 dB |

STEP 7

# Before you post

- [ ] Watch it at phone size. Can every title be read in under a second?
- [ ] Under 60 seconds, end included. Ours is 56.
- [ ] Captions and titles never overlap, and nothing important sits in the bottom fifth.
- [ ] The last frame loops cleanly into the first (ours ends on the box closing, then opens again).
- [ ] Every fact has a source you could link in the comments.

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